



► **ASK AROUND AND** there's a good chance that at least one of your acquaintances has recently been to Spain or is planning to visit. Over the last few years, the country has emerged as a popular destination for Indian tourists. The vast majority end up travelling to Madrid or Barcelona, or to islands like Ibiza and Majorca. Few, if any, make it to Valencia—Spain's third-largest city.

I recently found myself planning a Spanish holiday with an eight-year-old, which meant that outdoor activities and parks took precedence over museums, which the country is famous for. Valencia, located on the east coast of the Iberian Peninsula and an easy two-hour train ride from Madrid, proved to be the perfect weekend add-on to our trip to the Spanish capital.

Historically, the city was built along the banks of the Turia river, which was drained and rerouted after a devastating flood in 1957. The riverbed has since been turned into a central park—Jardine des Turia or Turia Gardens—which runs along the centre of the city, dotted with playgrounds and football fields. The most popular among these is Gulliver Park. The central attraction is a 60-metre reclining statue built in the likeness of Jonathan Swift's popular character.

The City of Arts and Sciences (*Ciudad de las Artes y las Ciencias*) is located at one end of the Turia Gardens and is the primary reason that makes Valencia a child-friendly destination. Often called one of the most important modern tourist destinations in the city, it was also the only site from Valencia to feature on a recent 12 Treasures of Spain listing.

MAJESTIC VALENCIA
A view of the Assut
de l'Or Bridge, the City of
Arts and Sciences